

THE ILLITERATE WRITER'S

FILM FORUM

THE ELEMENTS OF FILM · PART ONE · STORY

CHAPTER 3 · POINT OF VIEW

*Whose eyes the story lends you, and what it costs to
borrow them.*

SUNSET BLVD.

The Truman Show · 1998 · 103 min · dir. Peter Weir · written by
Andrew Niccol · Paramount

*This is the print edition, with everything the online guide has. Some
information will include spoilers, advised to stop at the end of "Before you
press play" and resume after the credits.*

THE TWO ROADS

STRAIGHT ON, OR A LEFT AT THE VISTA

Hollywood Boulevard runs east until it hits Sunset, and there is a theatre standing on the corner where they meet. Every chapter the room decides at that corner.

*Two films about the act of watching, built from opposite ends of the lens. In *Rear Window* you are the watcher: you sit in one man's chair, you see what he sees, and the film almost never lets you leave the room. In *The Truman Show* you are the audience of a man being watched by everyone, and the film keeps swapping whose eyes you are using — his, the hidden cameras', the control room's, the viewers' at home.*

One locks the point of view down tighter than almost any film ever made. The other splits it five ways. Both end with somebody looking straight back.

SUNSET BLVD.

THE TRUMAN SHOW

1998 · 103 min · dir. Peter Weir · written by Andrew Niccol · Paramount

An insurance salesman slowly realises his whole life has been a television show, broadcast around the clock to the whole world.

Why it is on the ballot. Where *Rear Window* never lets you out of one man's eyes, this film cannot decide whose eyes you should be using, and that is the point. You watch Truman, you watch the people watching Truman, and you watch the man who decides what everyone sees. By the end you have to ask which audience you belong to.

01

BEFORE YOU PRESS PLAY

Optional trivia.

IT ARRIVED BEFORE REALITY TV DID

It opened on 5 June 1998. Dutch *Big Brother* began fifteen months later, in September 1999, and *Survivor* reached American television in May 2000. The film predicted a genre before the genre had a name.

SEAHAVEN IS A REAL TOWN

The picture-perfect island was shot largely in Seaside, Florida, a planned resort town on the Gulf coast that already looked like that. The production barely had to dress it.

CHRISTOF WAS CAST TWICE, AND THE SECOND ONE HAD A WEEKEND TO PREPARE

Dennis Hopper was cast as the show's creator and left after filming began. Ed Harris came in at the last minute: "It was a Friday. I think I started work on Monday." He was nominated for an Oscar for it.

02

WHILE YOU WATCH

Open each one only when you reach it.

THE OPENING CREDITS

Whose film is starting?

The first credits you see are the show's, not the movie's. Truman Burbank is billed "as himself."

Why it matters: Before the story begins, the film has told you that you are watching the programme, not a movie about it.

WATCH THE EDGES

Hidden-camera shots

A great many shots are taken from odd places, with dark vignetted corners like a keyhole: a car radio, a button, a bathroom mirror. Cinematographer Peter Biziou built them with very wide lenses and masks in front of the glass, and one camera really was a lens dropped into the cavity of Truman's car radio.

Why it matters: Those shots are the show's point of view. Notice when the film switches to a clean, normal camera, and ask whose eyes those are.

EARLY ON

Something falls out of the sky

A studio light crashes into the street in front of Truman. Read the label: "Sirius (9 Canis Major)."

Why it matters: It is the first crack in the world, and the film hands you the joke before Truman understands it. Being a step ahead of him is its own kind of point of view. Sirius is really Alpha Canis Majoris, so even the label is a fake.

MID-ARGUMENT

The cocoa

In the middle of a real fight, Meryl turns toward an unseen camera: "Why don't you let me fix you some of this new Mococoa drink? All natural cocoa beans from the upper slopes of Mount Nicaragua. No artificial sweeteners."

Why it matters: It is funny and horrible at once. She is performing for a camera Truman cannot see, and for a second, so are you.

AFTER THE CREDITS

Everything here gives the film away. Keep it for afterwards.

OPEN

The script started much darker

Andrew Niccol's draft was a thriller set in a rain-soaked artificial New York, with a drinking, unravelling Truman. Weir moved it into bright suburban daylight, on the reasoning that nobody would watch something that grim twenty-four hours a day. The trap is harder to see because it is sunny.

OPEN

It gave its name to a real condition

In 2008 the brothers Joel Gold, a psychiatrist, and Ian Gold, a philosopher of psychiatry, described patients convinced they were being filmed for a show. They called it the "Truman Show delusion."

OPEN

Three Oscar nominations, no wins

Ed Harris for Supporting Actor, Peter Weir for Directing, Andrew Niccol for Original Screenplay. It lost all three. The film's last line belongs to two viewers on a couch, asking what else is on.

01 The film shows Truman through hidden cameras and through its own "normal" camera. Is there any difference, or were you watching the show the whole time?

02 Christof says Truman could leave at any time. Is that true?

03 The final line goes to two people on a couch. Who is the film actually about?

Where to watch

Find it here → [The Truman Show on JustWatch](#), which shows every service carrying it right now, including free ones.

And two nobody uses: **Kanopy** and **Hoopla** are free with a library card. If you find it cheaper or free somewhere else, post the link in [my Substack](#).

Sources: AFI Catalog · American Cinematographer · The Hollywood Reporter · the Academy's awards database

THE LESSON

THE CAMERA DOESN'T LIE

HENRY JAMES DESCRIBED WHAT HE WAS DOING

In the prefaces he wrote for the New York Edition of his novels, published 1907 to 1909, Henry James explained his habit of telling a story through one character's consciousness — what he called a "centre" or a "reflector." It was a working novelist describing his own method, and he never used the phrase "point of view" for it.

PERCY LUBBOCK TURNED IT INTO A LAW

In 1921 the critic Percy Lubbock, who was James's literary executor, published *The Craft of Fiction* and made that habit the whole art: "The whole intricate question of method, in the craft of fiction, I take to be governed by the question of the point of view." The phrase is his, not James's. From there it became a classroom rule, and eventually "show, don't tell." One novelist's working method hardened into the standard for everyone.

HOLLYWOOD'S VERSION: THE CAMERA TELLS THE TRUTH

Film grew its own form of the rule. What the camera shows you, happened. In 1950 Alfred Hitchcock broke it in *Stage Fright*, opening with a flashback that turns out to be a lie. Audiences felt cheated, and he later called it one of his biggest mistakes. Four years later he made *Rear Window*, where the camera almost never shows you anything Jeff did not see.

THREE WAYS A FILM CAN LEND YOU ITS EYES

ONE

RESTRICTED

You know only what one character knows, and you find things out when they do.

Rear Window · Memento · Parasite's first half

TWO

UNRESTRICTED

The film shows you more than any character knows, and the tension comes from watching them walk into it.

Psycho · Jaws · The Shining

THREE

SUBJECTIVE

The camera becomes a character's eyes, for a shot or for a whole film.

Lady in the Lake · Hardcore Henry · found footage

The Truman Show is a fourth case: a film that passes the camera between characters until you keep changing sides.

ONE PIECE OF VOCABULARY

Hitchcock separated **surprise** from **suspense** using a bomb under a table. If it simply explodes, the audience gets a shock. If they were shown the bomb first, the same scene becomes unbearable: "In the first case we have given the public fifteen seconds of surprise at the moment of the explosion. In the second we have provided them with fifteen minutes of suspense." The only thing that changed is what the point of view let them know.

WHY THESE FILMS

Chapter 1 was the shape of a story and chapter 2 was its clock. This chapter is the narrator: who is holding the camera, and whether you trust them. One film keeps you in one chair. The other hands you around a room full of watchers until you realise you are one of them.

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Questions, arguments, films you want on the ballot: heyilliteratewriter@gmail.com

Facts in this guide are drawn from the AFI Catalog, TCM, American Cinematographer, the Academy's awards database, the Yale Film Archive and contemporary reporting. Where sources disagree, the disagreement is printed rather than resolved.

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